

STAGE FOURTEEN • PROJECT MANAGEMENT

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 30 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Fourteen • Project Management

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Fourteen, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Fourteen covers thirty FIRSTS across three sections: Project Planning Foundations, Managing Execution, and Modern Methodologies & Closing Out. Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt.

This stage is more procedural and structured than most, which makes it a natural fit for participants who want concrete frameworks. The real risk is treating it as purely theoretical — push participants throughout to apply every FIRST to a genuinely real project, not a hypothetical one.

SESSION 1

Project Planning Foundations

Covers *FIRSTS R1–R10*

FIRST R1

Project Management Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map a past project against the five lifecycle phases (initiation, planning, execution, monitoring, closure) and identify at least one phase that was skipped or rushed.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a mental map of the full project lifecycle, it's easy to skip genuinely important phases, like formal closure, simply because you didn't know they were a distinct, necessary step.
- Most people, before this exercise, think of “project management” as just the execution phase — doing the actual work.
- This awareness is the foundation for every other FIRST in this stage.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming project management is just about the execution phase, missing the genuine value of formal initiation, planning, and closure.
 - Treating the five phases as purely academic rather than something to actually apply to a real, remembered project.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R2

Project Initiation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a brief initiation document (purpose, outcome, why it matters, key stakeholders) for a real or upcoming project.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Projects that begin without a formal, explicit definition of purpose and outcome often drift, with stakeholders quietly assuming different things about success.
- Skipping initiation because a project feels urgent is a common, costly shortcut — clarifying purpose upfront usually pays for itself many times over.
- This is the first concrete step that turns lifecycle awareness (R1) into actual practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping formal initiation because a project feels urgent, when the time spent clarifying purpose upfront usually pays for itself many times over.
- Treating initiation as a bureaucratic formality rather than a genuine clarity-building step.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R3

Project Scope Defined

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write an explicit in-scope and out-of-scope list for a real project.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Undefined scope is one of the most common sources of project failure — work quietly expands (“scope creep”) without anyone explicitly deciding it should.
- Defining only what's included, without naming what's excluded, leaves the actual boundary genuinely ambiguous.
- A clear scope document becomes the reference point for every future change request (R15).

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only defining what's included, without explicitly naming what's excluded, which leaves the boundary genuinely ambiguous.
 - Assuming scope is obvious from the project's name or general description.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R4

Project Requirements Gathered

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants ask a real stakeholder what underlying problem they're actually trying to solve, not just what they initially requested.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Projects built on assumed requirements, rather than genuinely gathered ones, often deliver something technically complete but not actually what stakeholders needed.
- Taking a stakeholder's initial request at face value, without probing for the real underlying need, is an easy and common trap.
- This connects directly to genuine listening skills built in earlier stages — the goal here is the same disciplined curiosity applied to project scope.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Taking a stakeholder's initial request at face value without probing for the genuine underlying need it's meant to address.
 - Assuming your own interpretation of a request is automatically correct without confirming it.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R5

Project Deliverables Defined

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map each gathered requirement to a specific, tangible deliverable, and check for any requirement without a corresponding deliverable.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Vague deliverables (“improve the process”) make it genuinely impossible to know when a project is actually complete.
- Specific, tangible deliverables give a project a real, checkable finish line.
- This directly sets up formal closure (R28), which depends entirely on deliverables being concrete enough to verify.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Defining deliverables vaguely enough that it's unclear whether the project has actually produced them or not.
- Assuming every requirement automatically has an obvious corresponding deliverable without explicitly checking.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R6

Project Timeline Created

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a timeline for a real project explicitly showing milestones and dependencies, not just a flat task list.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A genuine timeline, not just a task list, gives the whole team a shared, explicit understanding of when things will happen and in what order.
- Building a task list without explicit milestones or dependencies misses genuine scheduling conflicts until they actually happen.
- This is where planning starts to become concrete and checkable, not just conceptual.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Building a task list without explicit milestones or dependencies, which misses genuine scheduling conflicts until they actually happen.
- Treating the timeline as fixed once created, rather than a living document.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R7

Project Work Breakdown

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants break their project's largest deliverable into specific, assignable tasks with clear completion criteria.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A deliverable too large or vague to actually assign and track needs to be broken down into genuinely manageable pieces first.

- Leaving deliverables too large or vague makes it unclear who owns what or when something is genuinely done.
- This is the direct link between planning and real delegation — you can't fairly assign what hasn't been broken down.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving deliverables too large or vague to actually assign, which makes it unclear who owns what or when something is genuinely done.
- Breaking work down so granularly that tracking the breakdown itself becomes a burden.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST R8

Project Resource Plan

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify the resources each major task requires and confirm availability for anything not yet certain.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Projects that don't explicitly plan resources often discover mid-project that something genuinely isn't available, causing avoidable delays.
- Assuming resources will be there without confirming it during planning is a common, preventable mistake.
- This is a natural moment to reference budget thinking from Stage Seven, since resources and cost are closely linked.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming needed resources will be available without explicitly confirming it during planning, discovering gaps only once execution has already begun.
- Confusing a resource being requested with a resource being confirmed and secured.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST R9

Project Risk Register

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants create a risk register with a specific, real mitigation plan for each significant risk identified.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Risks identified proactively can be planned for; risks discovered only once they've already happened are far more costly to address.
- A risk register created once at kickoff but never revisited loses its value as the project evolves and new risks emerge.
- This is a living document, not a one-time exercise — emphasize that explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Creating a risk register once at project kickoff but never revisiting it as the project evolves and new risks emerge.
 - Listing risks without any real, specific mitigation plan attached to each one.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST R10

Project Dependency Map

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map task dependencies for a real project and identify at least one genuine bottleneck this reveals.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Dependencies left implicit are easy to miss until a task is blocked waiting on another that hasn't started — an avoidable delay.
- Treating all tasks as independent when genuine dependencies exist leads to tasks starting before their prerequisites are complete.
- This closes the planning section by connecting timeline (R6), work breakdown (R7), and resources (R8) into one coherent sequencing view.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating all tasks as independent when genuine dependencies exist, which leads to tasks starting before their prerequisites are actually complete.
 - Mapping dependencies once and never revisiting them as the project's actual scope or timeline shifts.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 2

Managing Execution

Covers *FIRSTS R11–R20*

FIRST R11

Project Stakeholder Map

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map every stakeholder for a real project by influence and interest, and identify anyone genuinely important they hadn't initially considered.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Projects that don't explicitly map all relevant stakeholders often miss someone genuinely important until late in the project, when input is far harder to incorporate.
- Only mapping the most obvious, directly involved stakeholders misses higher-influence people who aren't part of day-to-day execution.
- This is the foundation for the entire execution section — communication planning (R12) depends directly on this map.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only mapping the most obvious, directly involved stakeholders, missing higher-influence people who aren't part of day-to-day execution.
- Treating the stakeholder map as static once built, rather than revisiting it as the project evolves.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R12

Project Communication Plan

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a communication plan tailoring frequency and detail to each stakeholder group's actual need.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Ad hoc communication tends to leave some stakeholders over-informed and others genuinely out of the loop.
- Using the same communication frequency and detail level for everyone, regardless of actual need, wastes some people's time and under-serves others.
- This directly extends the stakeholder map from R11 — without it, this plan has nothing real to tailor to.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using the same communication frequency and detail level for every stakeholder, regardless of their actual need for information.
- Building a communication plan once and never checking whether it's actually being followed.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R13

Project Status Report

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants produce a status report using a consistent format covering progress, risks, and next steps.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A consistent format lets stakeholders track a project's real health over time, rather than reconstructing it from scattered updates each time.
- Varying the report's format or content each time makes it harder for stakeholders to track genuine trends across multiple updates.
- This is a recurring practice, not a one-time deliverable — frame it that way explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Varying the report's format or content each time, which makes it harder for stakeholders to track genuine trends over multiple updates.
- Treating a status report as purely a formality rather than a genuine communication tool.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R14

Project Milestone Achieved

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants explicitly confirm that a real milestone's underlying criteria were genuinely met, not just that its target date arrived.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Milestones give a project concrete, checkable points to confirm real progress, rather than only discovering success or failure at the very end.
- Treating a milestone as achieved simply because its date passed, without confirming the underlying criteria, creates a false sense of progress.
- This is a genuine verification habit, distinct from just tracking dates on a calendar.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating a milestone as achieved simply because its target date has passed, without explicitly confirming the underlying criteria were genuinely met.
- Assuming milestone criteria are obvious without ever writing them down explicitly during planning.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R15

Project Change Request

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants document a proposed scope change's real impact and get explicit approval before incorporating it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unmanaged changes to scope, absorbed without formal evaluation, are one of the most common ways projects quietly exceed their original timeline and budget.
- Silently absorbing scope changes to avoid a difficult conversation erodes the project without any explicit, informed decision.
- This directly protects the scope boundary defined back in R3.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Silently absorbing scope changes to avoid a difficult conversation, which erodes the project's timeline and budget without any explicit, informed decision.
- Treating every proposed change as automatically worth accepting without evaluating its real impact.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R16

Project Issue Log

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants create an issue log and track a real issue through to resolution with a clear owner and status.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Issues tracked only in memory or scattered messages tend to get lost or forgotten before they're genuinely resolved.
- A formal log ensures real accountability for resolution, distinct from a risk register's focus on potential future problems.
- This complements R9's risk register by covering issues that have already occurred.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Tracking issues only in scattered, informal messages, which makes it easy for a genuine issue to get lost or forgotten.
- Confusing an issue log with a risk register — one tracks what's already happened, the other what might.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R17

Project Risk Mitigation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants take the concrete mitigation action their risk register called for on a specific, significant risk.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A risk register that only identifies risks without ever acting on the mitigation plans provides false comfort rather than genuine protection.
- Documenting a mitigation plan but never actually executing it leaves the project with no real protection when the risk materializes.
- This moves R9's risk register from documentation into genuine, verified action.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Documenting a mitigation plan in your risk register but never actually executing it, which provides no real protection when the risk materializes.
- Waiting until a risk has already become a real problem before acting on the mitigation plan.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R18

Project Budget Created

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants create a budget based on their resource plan and track actual spending against it weekly.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A project without an explicit, tracked budget risks discovering cost overruns only once they've already happened.
- Creating a budget estimate at the start but never tracking real spending against it defeats the entire purpose of having one.
- This directly extends the resource plan from R8 into real financial tracking.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Creating a budget estimate at the start but never actually tracking real spending against it throughout the project.
- Treating budget tracking as a finance-team task rather than a core project management responsibility.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R19

Project Schedule Updated

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants compare a real project's actual progress against the original schedule and update it honestly to reflect reality.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A schedule never updated to reflect real progress quickly becomes fiction, useless for anyone trying to understand where the project stands.
- Leaving an outdated schedule unrevised because it feels like admitting the project is behind only delays the reckoning and confuses everyone.
- This requires genuine honesty, not just a mechanical update — name that directly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving an outdated schedule unrevised because updating it feels like admitting the project is behind, which just delays the reckoning and confuses everyone relying on it.
 - Updating dates without examining why the original schedule slipped.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST R20

Project Management Tool Used

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants consolidate their project's timeline, tasks, and dependencies into one dedicated project management tool.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Dedicated tools offer far more structured support than an ad hoc task list, especially as project complexity grows.
- Using a tool for only task tracking while keeping timeline, budget, and risk in separate documents undercuts most of its real value.
- This closes the execution section by consolidating everything built across R1-R19 into one coherent system.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using a project management tool for only task tracking while keeping timeline, budget, and risk information in separate, disconnected documents.
 - Choosing a tool for its features rather than for whether the whole team will genuinely use it.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 3

Modern Methodologies & Closing Out

Covers *FIRSTS R21–R30*

FIRST R21

Agile Project Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one specific way a real project they were part of adapted based on feedback partway through.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Agile approaches are increasingly standard across industries, and genuine hands-on experience with iterative planning complements the more traditional planning skills built in Sections 1 and 2.
- Trying to force a traditional, fully-fixed upfront plan onto a genuinely Agile project misses the point of its iterative, adaptive structure.
- This opens the final section by explicitly contrasting with the sequential planning covered so far, not replacing it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Trying to force a traditional, fully-fixed upfront plan onto a genuinely Agile project, missing the point of its iterative, adaptive structure.
 - Assuming Agile means no planning at all, rather than short, iterative planning cycles.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R22

Scrum Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify the specific purpose of a Scrum ceremony before participating in it, and can explain it afterward.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Scrum is one of the most widely adopted specific Agile frameworks; genuine familiarity with its ceremonies and roles is broadly valuable.
- Treating Scrum ceremonies as generic meetings, without understanding each one's distinct purpose, wastes their actual structure.
- This directly extends R21's broader Agile awareness into one specific, widely used framework.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating Scrum ceremonies as generic meetings without understanding the distinct, specific purpose each one is actually designed to serve.
- Assuming Scrum's specific ceremonies and roles are optional formalities rather than functional parts of the framework.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R23

Kanban Workflow

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up a Kanban board for a piece of ongoing, unpredictable work and manage it for two weeks.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Kanban's visual, continuous-flow approach suits certain kinds of work, particularly ongoing or unpredictable work, better than Scrum's fixed sprints.
- Forcing a Kanban board onto work that would actually benefit more from Scrum's structured sprint planning, or vice versa, undercuts either approach.
- This presents Kanban as a genuinely distinct methodology, not a lesser or simplified version of Scrum.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Forcing a Kanban board onto work that would actually benefit more from Scrum's structured sprint planning, or vice versa.
- Treating Kanban as requiring less discipline than Scrum, rather than a genuinely different kind of discipline.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R24

Project Progress Review

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants conduct an honest progress review for a real project, comparing actual against planned progress.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Regular, honest progress review is what lets a project manager course-correct before small delays compound into significant, harder-to-fix problems.
- Conducting progress reviews optimistically rather than honestly, glossing over real delays, defeats the entire purpose of reviewing.
- This is a genuine discipline of honesty, not just a scheduling checkpoint.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Conducting progress reviews optimistically rather than honestly, glossing over real delays or issues rather than genuinely confronting them.
- Reviewing progress against the original plan without ever considering whether the plan itself needs to change.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R25

Project Escalation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify what would genuinely warrant escalation in their context, and the appropriate person and process for it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Knowing when and how to escalate appropriately, rather than avoiding a genuine blocker or overreaching beyond your authority, is a critical skill.
- Both avoiding a necessary escalation and escalating vaguely without a clear ask are common, real failure modes.
- This connects directly to Leadership Without Authority from Stage Twelve — escalation is itself a form of influence.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Either avoiding a necessary escalation out of a desire to seem self-sufficient, or escalating vaguely without a specific, clear ask.
- Assuming escalation reflects poorly on the person escalating, rather than being a normal, responsible project management action.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST R26

Project Recovery Plan

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants develop a specific recovery plan addressing the genuine root cause of a real or hypothetical project delay.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Projects that fall behind rarely recover by simply continuing as before; a deliberate plan addressing the actual root cause is what genuinely helps.
- Responding to a struggling project by just pushing harder on the original plan, without addressing why it fell behind, usually fails again.
- This requires genuine diagnostic thinking, not just increased effort.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Responding to a struggling project by just pushing harder on the original plan, without addressing the genuine root cause of why it fell behind.
- Treating a recovery plan as just a revised deadline rather than a genuine change in approach.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R27

Project Handoff

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants document a thorough handoff package covering status, context, and ongoing needs for a real project transition.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A project's completed work only creates lasting value if it's genuinely handed off with enough context to actually maintain or use it going forward.
- Handing off only the final deliverable, without the genuine context behind it, leaves the receiving team unable to intelligently maintain or adapt the work.
- This directly extends the Team Handoff FIRST from Stage Thirteen into a formal, project-level transition.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Handing off only the final deliverable without the genuine context behind it, leaving the receiving team unable to intelligently maintain or adapt the work.
- Assuming a brief verbal summary is sufficient context for a genuine handoff.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R28

Project Closure

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants confirm explicitly with stakeholders that every deliverable in a real or recent project was genuinely met.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Projects that fade out rather than formally close often leave loose ends unaddressed and miss the chance to confirm all deliverables were actually met.
- Letting a project quietly fade out as people move to other work is a common, avoidable failure to formally close.
- This directly verifies the deliverables defined back in R5 — formal closure requires checking against something concrete.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting a project quietly fade out as people move to other work, rather than a deliberate, formal closure confirming genuine completion.
- Treating closure as automatic once the last task is finished, without explicit stakeholder confirmation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST R29

Project Lessons Learned

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants document specific, actionable lessons from a real project that a future project could genuinely apply.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Lessons that only live in memory tend to fade and get relearned the hard way on future projects.
- Writing lessons so vague (“communicate better”) provides no genuine, actionable guidance for a future project to actually apply.
- This directly extends the Team Lesson-Learned Document FIRST from Stage Thirteen into a formal project management artifact.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing lessons so vague (“communicate better”) that they provide no genuine, actionable guidance for a future project to actually apply.
- Documenting lessons but never actually referencing them when planning the next project.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST R30

End-to-End Project Managed

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one upcoming project they can independently manage end-to-end, committing to apply the full lifecycle.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Managing a full project independently, from genuine initiation through formal closure, is what actually proves the accumulated skill built throughout this stage.
- Applying individual practices in isolation across different projects, without ever managing one project through its full lifecycle, misses the real, compounding value of this stage.
- This is the capstone — explicitly connect it back to R1's lifecycle map as the starting point this whole stage has been building toward applying fully.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Applying individual project management practices in isolation across different projects without ever independently managing one project through its full lifecycle.
- Treating this as a final test rather than the beginning of an ongoing professional practice.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*